

“From the **wedding day**, the **young matron** should **shape her life** to the probable and desired **contingency of conception** and **maternity**. Otherwise she has **no right** or **title to wifehood**.”

EMMA FRANCES ANGELL DRAKE, *WHAT A YOUNG WIFE OUGHT TO KNOW*, 1902

pays *mahr*—money, gifts, or possessions—to his bride. The form that bride price and dowry take has varied across cultures; men of the Maasai tribe in Kenya, for example, pay the bride’s mother in goats, cows, and sheep, which are precious commodities within the community.

A clandestine affair

If a marriage choice did not gain parental approval, lovers often eloped or married in secret. In 18th-century England, the most popular venue for clandestine weddings was London’s Fleet Prison. Due to a legal quirk, the debtor’s prison was not subject to the usual regulations, meaning that couples could marry there with no questions asked and at very little cost. Other English couples wishing to evade the constraints of the 1754 Marriage Act, which introduced an age of consent of 21, eloped to Scotland, where boys could marry at 14 and girls at 12 without parental consent. In the slave-era American South, marriage between slaves was viewed with suspicion by slave owners who thought it could threaten their authority or decrease productivity. As a result slave marriages were not legally binding and could be overruled by owners. Slave weddings were often informal and conducted with little ceremony. The couple would jump over a broom to symbolize their union, a custom now practiced in fun.

Wedding customs continue to vary widely across different societies. For a month before their wedding, Tujia brides in central China must cry for one hour a day to show gratitude

to their family. Elsewhere, in the northwestern African nation of Mauritania—in contrast to the pre-wedding diet cultures of the United States and elsewhere—brides are sent to “fattening camps” before marriage so that they gain weight, because obesity is seen as a symbol of the family’s prosperity.

When Britain’s Queen Victoria wore a white bridal gown at her nuptials in 1840 it was an unusual choice for the era. She set a tradition that continues to modern times, although, outside Western cultures, white is not the traditional color of choice—in China, for example, it is typically red, whereas in Africa bright patterns are often preferred. The “white wedding” has its roots in the belief in a bride’s purity. Across history, marriage dictated people’s sexual behavior: intercourse was only allowed between spouses. This was important for women to uphold, as premarital virginity ensured the paternity of any children.

“All marriage is such a **lottery** ... though it may be a very happy one, still the **poor woman** is **bodily** and **morally** the **husband’s slave**.”

QUEEN VICTORIA TO HER DAUGHTER, MAY 16, 1860



▲ Bridal coat

In Qing China, wedding attire was embellished with motifs such as pomegranates, which were a symbol of fertility. The phoenix and dragon represented the bride and groom, respectively, while the color red was associated with luck.